

Everything Feels Fake, Cultural Mediation, and Reality Drift

Why Modern Life Can Remain Functional While Losing Contact With Lived Experience

Reality Drift Cultural Systems Brief #8

A. Jacobs – Reality Drift Project

The Basic Pattern

Many people describe a growing sense that modern life feels increasingly artificial, performative, or strangely detached from everyday experience. They are often unable to identify a single cause. Instead, the feeling emerges across many different parts of life. Social media feels less personal, institutions feel less responsive, products require more administration, online information feels increasingly repetitive, and digital interactions often seem to replace rather than support direct experience.

At the same time, most systems continue functioning. Stores remain open, governments continue operating, technology continues improving, businesses continue growing, and information remains more abundant than ever before. Modern society appears increasingly sophisticated even as many people describe an underlying sense that something has become less genuine.

This experience is often discussed using phrases such as **"why everything feels fake," "why modern life feels fake," "internet culture," "AI-generated content," "performative culture,"** and **"digital life."** These descriptions identify different aspects of a broader cultural experience without necessarily explaining why they appear together.

Reality Drift provides a structural framework for understanding this pattern. Modern systems can remain highly functional while gradually becoming more responsive to representations of reality than to reality itself.

When Representation Becomes Everyday Experience

Modern life is increasingly encountered through representations before direct experience. Restaurants are judged through reviews, people through profiles, products through ratings, and places through photographs. News arrives through feeds, while artificial intelligence often summarizes knowledge before people reach the original source.

These representations are useful because they reduce uncertainty and make complex environments easier to navigate. The shift occurs when they stop merely supporting experience and begin

becoming the main environment through which experience is understood. What was once a guide to reality starts to function as the reality people interact with most directly.

The deeper question is not whether modern life has become fake. It is whether everyday experience is increasingly mediated through systems that simplify reality so effectively that they begin replacing direct contact with it.

How Reality Drift Emerges

Stage 1 – Direct Experience

People primarily encounter the world through direct observation, personal relationships, physical environments, and lived experience. Representations remain closely connected to what they describe.

Stage 2 – Representation

Experiences become reviews, ratings, metrics, profiles, dashboards, documentation, recommendations, photographs, videos, databases, and digital identities that allow reality to be shared and organized.

Stage 3 – Optimization

Institutions, platforms, organizations, and individuals increasingly optimize these representations because they are measurable, scalable, searchable, and economically valuable.

Stage 4 – Reality Drift

Representational systems remain coherent while the relationship between those representations and lived experience gradually weakens. Daily life continues functioning, yet individuals increasingly navigate representations of reality rather than reality itself. Reality drift begins when continuation becomes easier than correction.

The absence of collapse is not proof that society remains fully aligned. It may simply indicate that representational systems have become increasingly successful at organizing themselves.

Semantic Fidelity and Constraint Collapse

Modern societies increasingly evaluate reality through measurable representations. Ratings represent quality. Credentials represent competence. Engagement represents interest. Productivity metrics represent work. Administrative procedures represent service. Followers represent influence. Reviews represent experience.

Semantic Fidelity asks a different question. Do these representations continue preserving the realities they were originally intended to communicate?

A five-star rating may accurately summarize customer feedback while communicating very little about an individual's experience. A productivity dashboard may correctly measure activity while revealing relatively little about meaningful accomplishment. A social media profile may genuinely represent aspects of a person's life while omitting the experiences that make those moments meaningful.

Constraint Collapse emerges when lived reality gradually loses its ability to correct the representational systems built upon it. Metrics increasingly influence behavior, platforms increasingly shape communication, institutions increasingly organize administration around documentation, and algorithms increasingly determine visibility. Reality remains present, but it becomes progressively less influential than the representations designed to describe it.

The Representation Stack

Reality Drift develops as experience moves through increasingly mediated layers. Lived events become information, information becomes representation, and representation becomes measurement. Those measurements then guide optimization, which is eventually treated as evidence of institutional success and, over time, as a description of cultural reality.

Each step makes society easier to organize, but it also gives representations more influence over the realities they were meant to describe. This process has produced enormous technological, economic, and organizational gains. It has also created a world in which people often encounter dashboards, profiles, ratings, recommendations, and administrative systems before they encounter the underlying experience itself.

The further daily life moves through these representational layers, the more important it becomes to preserve meaningful contact with lived reality.

Examples Across Systems

Social Media: Personal relationships increasingly begin through profiles, posts, and algorithmically curated feeds that represent people's lives before direct interaction occurs.

Artificial Intelligence: AI systems summarize, retrieve, generate, and organize information through increasingly sophisticated representations that often become the first point of contact with knowledge.

Healthcare: Administrative systems, insurance procedures, documentation requirements, and electronic records increasingly mediate the experience of receiving care.

Consumer Life: Ratings, reviews, recommendations, loyalty programs, and digital platforms increasingly shape purchasing decisions before products are experienced directly.

Work: Dashboards, key performance indicators, productivity software, performance reviews, and reporting systems increasingly mediate how organizations understand work.

Public Institutions: Government services, education, financial systems, and regulatory processes increasingly organize citizens through documentation, verification, eligibility, and administrative representations.

Reality Drift as a General Principle

People often describe modern life as feeling fake because similar patterns appear across social media, bureaucracy, consumer culture, artificial intelligence, and public institutions without a shared language for explaining them. These systems seem unrelated, yet they increasingly organize experience through representations that can be measured, stored, searched, managed, and optimized.

Reality Drift describes what happens when those representations become more influential than the realities they were created to support. Modern systems can remain efficient, technologically advanced, and operational while growing more distant from lived experience. Ratings, profiles, dashboards, procedures, and algorithms continue functioning, but they begin shaping reality more than reflecting it.

The feeling that everything seems fake is often dismissed as nostalgia, cynicism, or a reaction to social media. Those explanations capture part of the experience, but they do not explain why the same pattern appears across work, healthcare, education, institutions, and everyday life. The deeper problem is structural. Systems remain coherent because their representations remain coherent, even as the relationship between those representations and lived reality weakens.

The challenge is therefore not simply to build more capable systems. It is to preserve meaningful contact between lived experience and the representations through which that experience is increasingly understood, organized, and governed.

Related Concepts

Reality Drift

The condition in which systems remain functional and coherent while gradually losing alignment with lived experience and real-world conditions.

Synthetic Realness

The increasing dominance of polished, optimized, and convincing representations that feel real while becoming more standardized and detached from direct experience.

Semantic Fidelity

The degree to which ratings, profiles, metrics, reviews, and other representations continue preserving the meaning of the realities they describe.

Constraint Collapse

The weakening of lived experience as a corrective force when metrics, procedures, and digital systems become more influential than the conditions they were meant to represent.

Optimization Trap

A condition in which systems become increasingly effective at improving measurable representations while becoming less responsive to the purposes those measures were meant to serve.

Filter Fatigue

The cognitive burden created by constantly sorting through ratings, profiles, feeds, recommendations, and other mediated representations of everyday life.

Frequently Asked Questions

Why does modern life sometimes feel fake even when systems still work?

Because functionality does not guarantee contact with lived reality. Systems can remain efficient and operational while people increasingly interact with ratings, profiles, dashboards, and procedures rather than the underlying experiences themselves.

Is Reality Drift just another term for social media culture?

No. Social media is one example, but the same pattern can appear in work, healthcare, education, government, consumer systems, and artificial intelligence.

Does mediation always make experience less authentic?

No. Representations are necessary and often useful. The problem appears when they stop supporting direct experience and begin replacing it as the primary basis for judgment and action.

How does semantic fidelity apply to everyday life?

Semantic fidelity asks whether a representation still preserves what matters about the reality it stands in for. A rating may be accurate as a score while failing to communicate the experience behind it.

What causes representations to become more influential than reality?

Representations are easier to measure, compare, store, search, and optimize. Institutions and platforms therefore tend to organize around them, even when they capture only part of the underlying reality.

Canonical References

[Reality Drift: Canonical Concept Paper and Definition](#)

Explains how systems can remain functional while gradually losing alignment with real-world conditions.

[Synthetic Realness: Concept Paper and Definition](#)

Describes how representations can become more polished, convincing, and realistic while also becoming more standardized and interchangeable.

Optimization Trap: Concept Paper and Definition

Examines how systems optimized around measurable goals can improve internal metrics while weakening the purposes and constraints those metrics were meant to serve.

Filter Fatigue: Concept Paper and Definition

Defines the cognitive burden created when systems narrow choices but leave people to compare increasingly similar, personalized, and highly filtered options.

Related Search Terms

- why everything feels fake
- why modern life feels fake
- cultural mediation
- digital life
- performative culture
- algorithmic culture
- authenticity
- synthetic realness
- attention economy
- bureaucracy
- semantic fidelity
- constraint collapse
- filter fatigue
- optimization trap
- reality drift